The Essence of Dependent Origination

Pratītyasamutpādahṛdaya · Toh 981 · Derge Kangyur

རྟེན་ཅིང་འབྲེལ་བར་འབྱུང་བའི་སྙིང་པོ།

The Essence of Dependent Origination, known in Sanskrit as the Pratītyasamutpādahṛdaya and in Tibetan as Rten cing 'brel bar 'byung ba'i snying po, is a very brief text centered on the famous verse of dependent origination, which declares that the Tathāgata has taught the cause of phenomena that arise from causes, and also their cessation. After an opening homage to the buddhas, the text gives the verse in translation and in its Sanskrit form, beginning "ye dharmā hetu prabhavā," and then treats it as a mantra-like essence whose recitation brings great benefit. Reciting it even once is said to purify all misdeeds and turn back adverse forces, to transform any object one focuses on into a body of the Buddha or a stupa, and to make any offering as vast as one filling an entire world system. The work is Toh 981 in the Kangyur, where it belongs among the dhāraṇī texts, short formulas valued for their recitation and ritual power.

Homage to the buddhas, the blessed ones.

Of those phenomena that arise from causes,
the cause, and also their cessation,
have been declared by the Tathāgata.
Thus the Great Renunciant has spoken.

ye dharmā hetu prabhavā hetunteṣānta thāgato hya vadat teṣāñca yo nirodha evaṃ vādī mahāśramaṇaḥ

By reciting this essence just once, all misdeeds will be purified. All adverse forces will be pacified and turned back. If one recites it while focusing on any object, that object will become a body of the Buddha or a stupa. If one recites it while focusing on any offering, it will be as though one had offered enough to fill a whole world system.

The Essence of Dependent Origination is complete.

Translator's Notes

• "Great Renunciant" renders the epithet of the Buddha translated in Tibetan as "great virtue-trainer" (Skt. mahāśramaṇa), which also appears in the dhāraṇī itself.

Colophon

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Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.